

Cache Hackathon

APRIL 24–26, 2026

UNIVERSITY OF ILLINOIS URBANA-CHAMPAIGN

Hosted by **Zero2One**, **Founders**, and **BuildIllinois** · Sponsored by **Cache**





Event Overview

The Zero2One, Founders, and BuildIllinois Hackathon, sponsored by Cache, is a **weekend-long innovation event** bringing together students from technical and non-technical backgrounds to build, prototype, and pitch new ideas.

Focus Areas

- Entrepreneurship
- Emerging technology
- Real-world problem solving

What You'll Do

- Collaborate in small teams
- Develop a software product or startup concept
- Build around university intellectual property

Who Can Join

- UIUC students across all majors
- Engineering, business, design
- Sciences and other fields

Event Goals

The Cache Hackathon is built around three core goals that drive every aspect of the weekend experience.

1

Interdisciplinary Collaboration

Encourage collaboration between technical and non-technical students across majors and backgrounds.

2

Ideas Into Products

Help students turn ideas into viable products or startup concepts through hands-on building and pitching.

3

Entrepreneurship Exposure

Expose students to entrepreneurship, commercialization, and emerging technologies through workshops, sponsors, and judging.

- ✓ By the end of the weekend, teams will have created a prototype, pitch, commercialization plan, or startup concept ready to present to judges, sponsors, and campus leaders.

Hackathon Tracks

Participants will compete in one of two tracks, each offering a distinct approach to innovation and entrepreneurship.

Track 1

Software Track

Build a software product in 38 hours that solves a real problem. From prototype to pitch, show why it's a business — not just a project.

Track 2

University IP Commercialization Track

Choose a University of Illinois patented technology and pitch the startup you would build around it. Who is the customer, what is the business, and why are you the team to do it?



Software Track

38 HOURS TO BUILD

Prompt: Build a software product in 38 hours that solves a real problem. From prototype to pitch, show why it is a business, not just a project.

Teams will design and prototype a software solution that addresses a real-world problem with clear potential for market adoption. The problem can come from everyday life, a specific industry, or an emerging space.

→ A Meaningful Pain Point

Identify a real problem worth solving with a clear target user or customer.

→ Working Prototype

Deliver a functional or demonstrable prototype with strong usability and differentiation.

→ Path to a Startup

Show a realistic path toward becoming a scalable product or startup.

Teams may explore any domain — healthcare, education, sustainability, finance, productivity, social impact, and more. Creative use of AI, compute, APIs, or emerging technologies may be considered a bonus.

Software Track Judging Rubric

MAX SCORE: 25 POINTS

EACH CATEGORY: 1–5

Category	Score 1	Score 3	Score 5
Technical Execution	Broken or minimal demo	Functional with some rough edges	Polished, working demo with clear technical depth
Business Viability	No market or monetization thought	Some idea of customer or revenue	Clear market, go-to-market angle, and path to revenue
Innovation & Creativity	Generic or copycat idea	Incremental improvement on existing solution	Novel approach or insight that is hard to replicate
Product Design & UX	Confusing or incomplete UI	Usable but unpolished	Intuitive, well-designed experience
Pitch & Communication	Unclear or disorganized	Mostly clear with some gaps	Compelling, concise, and well-structured

University IP Commercialization Track

DEEP TECH ENTREPRENEURSHIP

Prompt: Choose a University of Illinois patented technology from the OTM list and pitch the startup you would build around it. Who is the customer, what is the business, and why are you the team to do it?

This track focuses on translating university research into potential startups. The University of Illinois Office of Technology Management maintains a portfolio of intellectual property developed at the university that has not yet been licensed, funded, or commercialized.

01

Select a Technology

Choose from the provided OTM IP portfolio list and research potential applications and markets.

02

Identify the Problem

Pinpoint a specific customer problem and build a startup concept around the technology.

03

Build the Business Case

Develop a pitch deck and commercialization strategy, then present to judges.

 Judges will evaluate the startup case being made around the IP — not the IP itself.

University IP Track Judging Rubric

MAX SCORE: 25 POINTS

EACH CATEGORY: 1–5

Category	Score 1	Score 3	Score 5
Technology Understanding	Misunderstands or misrepresents the IP	Basic grasp of what the technology does	Deep understanding of the technology and its defensibility
Problem & Market	Vague or no market identified	Problem is clear but market sizing is weak	Specific problem, credible market size, and real customer pain
Business Model	No monetization or go-to-market plan	Some revenue logic but incomplete	Clear, believable path to customers and revenue
Team & Execution Credibility	Roles unclear, no execution plan	Basic roles or plan outlined, but lacks detail	Clear roles and realistic roadmap with actionable next steps
Pitch Quality & Storytelling	Hard to follow, no narrative arc	Competent but forgettable	Memorable, well-paced, and makes judges want to invest

Weekend Schedule Overview

The hackathon spans three days — from Friday evening through Sunday midday — giving participants approximately **38 hours** to build, refine, and prepare their projects for judging.

1

Friday, April 24

Opening event, team formation, and brainstorming kick-off

2

Saturday, April 25

Full build day with workshops, lunch, and the Entrepreneurship Expo

3

Sunday, April 26

Submissions close, judging period, final presentations, and awards

□ Participants will have approximately **38 hours** to build, refine, and prepare their projects for judging.

Friday, April 24

OPENING NIGHT

Time	Event	Location
6:00–7:00 PM	Opening Event	iSchool, 614 E. Daniel, MP Room 4045

The opening event will introduce participants to the hackathon, tracks, rules, judging criteria, available resources, and weekend expectations.

Participants will also have time to **meet potential teammates** and begin brainstorming project ideas after the opening event concludes.

Saturday, April 25

FULL BUILD DAY

Time	Event	Location
1:00–2:00 PM	Workshop 1: Technical Workshop	Virtual
2:00–5:00 PM	Entrepreneurship Expo	iSchool, 614 E. Daniel, MP Room 5045
5:00–6:00 PM	Workshop 2: Pitching Workshop	Virtual

Technical Workshop

Hands-on exposure to a technical skill, tool, platform, API, or emerging technology that may support your project.

Entrepreneurship Expo

Sponsors, campus organizations, and UIUC-based startups table, connect with participants, and demonstrate technologies.

Pitching Workshop

Learn how to structure an effective startup pitch, explain your problem and solution clearly, and communicate business potential.

Sunday, April 26

FINAL DAY

Time	Event	Location
9:00 AM	Submissions Close	—
9:00–11:00 AM	Judging Period	iSchool, 614 E. Daniel, MP Room 4045
11:00 AM–12:00 PM	Awards	iSchool, 614 E. Daniel, MP Room 4045

Projects are due Sunday morning at **9:00 AM**. During the judging period, teams will present in a table-style demo format. Judges will circulate throughout the room, evaluate each team, and score projects using the track-specific rubrics. The event concludes with awards for top-performing teams.



Entrepreneurship Expo

SATURDAY, 2:00–5:00 PM

The Entrepreneurship Expo transforms the hackathon into more than just a competition — it creates a live ecosystem of builders, founders, sponsors, and campus innovators.



Table at the Event

Sponsors and organizations set up booths to showcase their work and connect with participants.



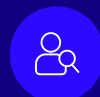
Connect with Builders

Meet student founders and technical builders actively working on real projects during the hackathon.



Demonstrate Technologies

Show off products, platforms, services, or tools to an engaged and curious student audience.



Recruit Talent

Identify and connect with technical and entrepreneurial talent from across UIUC and beyond.

Workshops

The hackathon will include two Saturday workshops designed to sharpen both technical skills and pitch delivery.

Workshop 1

Technical Workshop

Saturday, April 25 | 1:00–2:00 PM

This workshop will focus on a technical skill, platform, API, tool, or emerging technology that participants can apply directly during the hackathon build period.

Workshop 2

Pitching Workshop

Saturday, April 25 | 5:00–6:00 PM

This workshop will help teams improve how they communicate their ideas, structure their pitch, and explain the business potential behind their project to judges and sponsors.

Judging Format

SUNDAY, 9:00–11:00 AM

Judging will take place Sunday from **9:00–11:00 AM** in a table-style demo format. Judges will move between teams, ask questions, review prototypes or pitch decks, and score each project using the appropriate track rubric.

 Teams that present in person will receive **1 bonus point** added to their final judging score. If a team cannot attend in person, judges will review the team's submitted video instead.

Quality of the Idea

Is the problem real and the solution compelling?

Prototype or Business Concept

How strong is the execution — working demo or startup case?

Market & Customer Understanding

Does the team know who they're building for and why?

Execution Credibility

Can this team actually build and ship this product or startup?

Communication & Pitch Quality

Is the story clear, compelling, and well-structured?

Key Event Details

At a Glance

Event Name: Cache Hackathon

Hosted By: Zero2One, Founders, and BuildIllinois

Sponsored By: Cache

Dates: April 24–26, 2026

Location: University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

Primary Venue: iSchool, 614 E. Daniel

Participation Details

Primary Audience: UIUC students

Team Size: 1–3 members

Tracks: Software Track and University IP Commercialization Track

Final Submission Deadline: Sunday, April 26 at 9:00 AM

Judging: Sunday, April 26 from 9:00–11:00 AM

Awards: Sunday, April 26 from 11:00 AM–12:00 PM

Ready to Build?

The Cache Hackathon is your opportunity to turn an idea into something real — a working product, a startup pitch, or a commercialization plan built around cutting-edge university research.

1

Friday Evening

Opening event, team formation, and brainstorming

2

Saturday

Build, attend workshops, and explore the Entrepreneurship Expo

3

Sunday Morning

Submit by 9:00 AM and present to judges

4

Sunday Midday

Awards ceremony and celebration of the best teams

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